THE KEEFE TEAM · JLA REALTY · ALEDO, TEXAS

Buying Land & Acreage in Parker County

Acreage is where most of the surprises in real estate live. A pretty pasture can hide a dry well, an easement through the building site, a floodplain, or a deed restriction that stops the barn you were planning. We've bought, sold and lived on land west of Fort Worth for years. This is what we look at before our clients fall in love with a piece of ground. (We work all across DFW; the county offices change, the checklist doesn't.)



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1. Start with what you want to do on it

Horses, a shop, a second home for family, a few cattle for an ag exemption, or just quiet. Each one asks different things of the land. A homesite needs a buildable spot, utilities and access. Livestock needs fencing, water and pasture that holds up in August. A shop needs a level pad and a driveway a truck can use.

Write the list before you look. It keeps you from buying 20 acres when 5 would do, or 5 when you needed 20.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Decide the use first. The right acreage number falls out of the use, not the other way around.**

2. Water: well, co-op or city

Most rural Parker County property is on a private well or a water supply corporation, not a city line. For a well, ask for the driller's log, the depth, the gallons per minute, and when it was last tested. Have the water tested for bacteria and nitrates before closing. Ask the neighbors how their wells held up in the last drought.

For a water co-op, confirm there is a meter at the property or that one is available, and what the tap fee is. A meter that's "available" can cost thousands and take months.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **No water, no homesite. Verify water before you spend money on anything else.**

3. Septic and what the soil allows

If there's no sewer, you'll need an on-site septic system, and the type depends on the soil and the lot. Rocky or clay ground often means an aerobic system, which costs more to install and needs a maintenance contract. For an existing system, get it inspected and ask for the permit and maintenance records from Parker County's environmental health office.

For raw land, a soil evaluation tells you what kind of system the ground can support and roughly what it will cost before you commit.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Ask for the septic permit. If nobody can find one, assume you'll be paying for a new system.**

4. The survey, the fences and the easements

Get a current survey, and walk it. Fences in the country are often not on the property line, and a fence that's been in the wrong place for decades can turn into a dispute. Look for easements: utility lines, pipelines, shared driveways and access easements that let a neighbor cross your land, or that you need to cross theirs. An easement across the best building site changes the value of the whole tract.

Confirm the acreage on the survey matches the listing. "Approximately 10 acres" sometimes isn't.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Walk the corners with the survey in hand. It's a two-hour job that can save a six-figure mistake.**

5. Road access and who maintains it

Is the property on a county-maintained road, a private road, or an easement across someone else's land? Private roads mean you and the neighbors pay for grading and gravel, and the agreement to do that may be informal. Deeded legal access matters for your lender, your insurance and your resale.

Think about the driveway, too: distance from the road to the homesite, culverts, low-water crossings and whether a concrete truck, a horse trailer or a fire truck can get in.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Ask the seller to show you the recorded access. Landlocked parcels are hard to finance and hard to sell.**

6. Restrictions, zoning and the ETJ

Unincorporated Parker County has no zoning, but it does have subdivision rules, and many acreage tracts carry deed restrictions: minimum home size, no mobile homes, limits on livestock or businesses. Land inside a city or in a city's extraterritorial jurisdiction (ETJ) has more rules again, including platting and permitting. Pull the restrictions from the title company before you make an offer, and read every line.

Also check the floodplain map. Parts of the county along the Brazos, Clear Fork and the creeks flood, and building in a floodplain means insurance, elevation and permits.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Deed restrictions follow the land, not the seller. What the last owner got away with isn't permission.**

7. The ag exemption and what it takes to keep it

Many tracts carry an agricultural or wildlife valuation that keeps the property taxes low. It stays with the land only if you keep qualifying: cattle, hay, bees, wildlife management and so on, at the intensity the Parker County Appraisal District requires. Lose it, and you may owe rollback taxes for prior years. Ask what the land is currently qualified for, and talk to the appraisal district before you plan to change the use.

If you're building a home on part of the land, the homesite comes out of the ag valuation and is taxed at market value.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Ask for the current ag application. It tells you exactly what you have to keep doing to keep the tax bill.**

8. Utilities, internet and the things that aren't there yet

Electric service may need a line extension, and the co-op will quote the cost per pole. Propane replaces natural gas. Internet is improving across the county but varies by road, so check what actually serves the address, not what's advertised for the zip code. Trash pickup, mail delivery and school bus routes are worth a call, too.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Price the utilities into the land. A cheap tract with a $30,000 electric extension isn't cheap.**

9. Financing land is different

Raw land loans usually need a bigger down payment and come from local banks or farm credit lenders, not the big mortgage companies. If you're buying land and building, a construction-to-permanent loan rolls it together. If there's already a house on the acreage, a regular mortgage may work, but the appraiser will treat excess land and outbuildings differently than you'd expect.

We work with lenders who do this every week in Parker County. The right lender matters more here than anywhere.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Talk to a land lender before you shop. It changes which tracts are realistic.**

How we help

We'll walk the property with you, pull the restrictions and the survey, line up the well, septic and soil inspections, and tell you plainly what we'd do. Jennifer's construction background means you also get a builder's read on the homesite, the driveway and what the improvements will really cost.

Questions we hear most

How many acres do I need for horses in Parker County?

There's no single rule. It depends on deed restrictions, pasture quality and how you manage it. Our horse-property guide covers it in detail, and we'll evaluate a specific property with you.

Can I put a mobile or manufactured home on the land?

Only if the deed restrictions allow it, and many don't. Inside a city or ETJ there may be additional rules. Check before you buy.

What are rollback taxes?

If land loses its ag valuation because the use changes, the county can bill the difference between the ag taxes and market-value taxes for prior years, plus interest. Ask the appraisal district before changing anything.

Should I get a survey if the seller has an old one?

Usually yes, unless the old one is recent and the title company will accept it with a T-47 affidavit. Fences move, easements get added, and a new survey protects you.

Looking at land? Send us the listing and we'll tell you what to check first.

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